meals, MGNREGA and such, which today are the lifeline for many Indians. This ought to be celebrated, not derided.

If we move away from the distraction of freebies and bribes, the questions we ought to ask are about the democratic implications of this shift in our welfare architecture. As Keynes had famously quipped, "Anything we can do, we can afford." The question for debate really is what we choose to do and, more importantly, what we actively do not do. As I reflect on India's current preference for a cash transfer-based welfare regime, I worry that they risk distracting us from the real structural challenges that confront our economy while simultaneously feeding the authoritarian beast that our democracy is flirting with.

The intersection between two distinct but related features of our economy and polity have given rise to the current moment. First, India's economic model, which has failed to widen the growth pie. Growth, even as it lifted a large number of Indians out of poverty, has struggled with the challenge of underemployment and low inter-generational mobility, leaving the bulk of India (40 per cent in 2022) in what the World Bank classifies as the 'vulnerable population' or moderate poverty—one income shock away from falling back into poverty. More recently, successive blows to the informal economy from demonetisation to Covid lockdowns combined with stagnant wages have exacerbated the challenge. Unemployment and price rise, as every election survey highlights, are topmost on voters' minds. No political party can face the polls without responding to this reality.

Second, India's incompetent, corrupt State. Curiously, the lived reality of state failure when it comes to services that impact our everyday lives—education, health, clean air—has reduced the appetite both within the government and amongst the wider citizenry for any genuine investments in the state. Getting the state out of the way has been the dominant impulse and, technology, with its ability to bypass layers of the administration and deliver benefits 'directly' to citizens, offers a tantalising tool to achieve this.

Thus, rather than invest in strengthening public systems and aligning welfare expenditures to enhance productivity and build a welfare floor that de-commodifies labour and protects the economically vulnerable, as has been the traditional role of the welfare state; rather than investing in reimagining our economic trajectory to address the structural failure to create genuine economic opportunity for all; all of which will take years and for which credit attribution may be diffused, cash transfers have emerged as a quick fix. In this sense, cash transfers are a distraction, not a solution.

Politically, what has made cash transfers tantalising is their capacity for 'disintermediation'. The political legitimacy cash transfers enjoy lies in their ability to 'bypass' corrupt, incompetent layers of the state. But in doing so, they also enable party leaders to establish a direct 'emotive' connect with citizens. Cash transfers are easy to brand as 'guarantees' of the party leader. Embedded in this is a subtle shift in the social contract that positions welfare as the largesse of the leader toward the '*labharthi*' rather than a moral obligation of the state to rights-bearing citizens. This is what I have characterised with co-author Neelanjan Sircar as 'techno-patrimonial' welfare. In a functioning democracy, citizens seek accountability and demand welfare services through local state actors, both politicians and bureaucrats. When welfare delivery is centralised in the persona of the party leader, not only does this fundamental accountability relationship break down, it legitimises the authority of the leader to centralise power within his/her persona and carry out all functions of the state in their name. This is patrimonialism, fuelled by the power of technology. This has electoral power as data show a close correlation between political attribution for welfare schemes—where the provision of benefits are attributed directly to party leaders—and voting choices.

IN 2025, COMPETITIVE WELFARISM WILL ENTRENCH ITSELF...WE MUST MOVE BEYOND IT, **ASK DEEPER QUESTIONS ABOUT WHAT THIS TREND IS DOING** FOR OUR ECONOMY AND DEMOCRACY

In 2025, competitive welfarism will entrench itself. Our politicians will continue to bask in the glory of the achievement of small amounts of cash being transferred into bank accounts and seek to mobilise the *labharthi*. As citizens, we must move beyond debating freebies, bribes and *revdis* and ask deeper questions about what this trend is doing for our economy and democracy. We have to reframe the cash transfer debate in 2025. ■

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